GLASSHOUSE

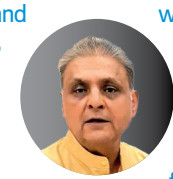
IN THE FIRING LINE



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Officials and elected representatives of West Bengal's 116 civic bodies did not know what hit them when they gathered at Nabanna on June 24. They faced some heavy artillery from CM **Mamata Banerjee**, who berated them for not delivering civic amenities to the public properly. Civic bodies were ranked best and worst on different parameters, and the TMC chief threatened to disband the existing boards, replaced the secretaries to the urban development and land reforms departments and even asked if she should pick up a broom herself to clean the roads. Fuelling Didi's ire is the fact that the BJP gained significant leads in 70 out of Bengal's 125 civic areas. In the Kolkata Municipal Corporation area itself, the TMC was trailing the BJP in 45 out of the 144 wards. The whole meeting was telecast live, so that no one missed Didi in 'action'.

DEFECTOR VS DEFECTOR



Back in 2017, **Jawahar Chavda** had won the Manavadar assembly seat in Gujarat on a Congress ticket, defected to the BJP, and won the bypoll again in 2019, becoming a minister in the Vijay Rupani government before the entire cabinet was sacked two years later. In the 2022 state polls, Chavda lost to Arvind Ladani, who, like him, won on a Congress ticket but later defected to the BJP. He has now won the bypoll, though Chavda, miffed that the BJP had chosen Ladani over him, had reportedly worked against Ladani and Mansukh Mandaviya, since Manavadar is part of the Porbandar LS seat. Local media is having a field day reporting Chavda's tantrums—from accusing BJP leaders of undermining him, attacking Mandaviya and tearing BJP posters in a recorded video message.

POOR SPORTS



BJP's review meetings in UP are fast becoming blame game arenas post its poor LS show. **Mahant Raju Das**, priest at Hanuman Garhi temple, blamed the district administration for the Faizabad loss at one such review meeting, offending DM Nitish Kumar and losing his security. At another meeting in Lucknow, BJP MLA Neeraj Bora lamented that police officials ignored what they had to say. In Muzaffarnagar, ex-BJP MP Sanjeev Balyan blamed ex-BJP MLA Sangeet Som for his loss.

Bungalow Battle



Just a week after Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief **Chirag Paswan** was appointed Union minister on June 9, the Bihar building construction department cancelled the allocation of a prime government bungalow near Patna airport. The house had been the office of Chirag's estranged uncle Pashupati Kumar Paras for his Rashtriya Lok Janshakti Party. Officially, the cancellation was due to the non-renewal of the allotment since 2019. The bungalow, initially allocated to the LJP in 2006, had become a point of contention after the party split in June 2021. However, with the BJP choosing Chirag over Paras, allotting his faction five seats, which they won, Paras was left out in the cold. Sources suggest LJP(RV) may now reclaim the bungalow.

Missing in Action

Things haven't been the same for Maharashtra deputy CM and Nationalist Congress Party president **Ajit Pawar** and senior ally BJP ever since he failed to deliver in the Lok Sabha election. But what raised eyebrows was the absence of Pawar, who also holds charge of the finance portfolio, from the GST Council's meeting. Enough fodder for the rival NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) to attack Ajit for skipping the meeting and failing to make a case for Maharashtra even while travelling to Delhi for "selfish reasons".



Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Prashant Srivastava and Dhaval S. Kulkarni

MANDAR DEODHAR